HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

Why Hold Back From What's Allowed? An Introduction to Perishut

Given Monday 19 October 2026 · HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem 10.1

Sefer: HaMaspik L'Ovdei Hashem (Rabbeinu Avraham ben HaRambam) — Rav Dana's Hebrew edition; Feldheim edition for the Torah commentary extracts

Chapter: Review of Chapters 1–9; Perek Yud (10) — **Perishut**, abstinence (Part 1)

Topic: A review of the sefer so far; two comments from Rabbeinu Avraham's commentary on Bereishit (**טוב מאד** and **ויפח**); body and soul, and why the material world is a barrier; how the pursuit of wealth swallows a life, whether it is hoarded or spent; **"the unlearned grow more foolish with age"**; the soul after death and **כף הקלע**; and Elisha's question to Gechazi, **העת לקחת?**

Schedule note: Rosh Chodesh Cheshvan 5787. We began this sefer in January–February, so we are nearly a year in; the plan is to **finish by Pesach**. **This week the shiur was at 6:15pm; from next week it returns to 6:00–7:00pm** for the winter unless otherwise notified. Chapter 10 should take about **four shiurim**; then Chapters 11, 12 and 13, and the sefer is complete.

A New Weekly Feature — Rabbeinu Avraham on the Parashah

Rabbeinu Avraham wrote a **commentary on the Torah** — probably on all five books, but only **Bereishit and Shemot** survive. It is not well known: it was **found only in the last hundred years or so**, and the Hebrew edition of Bereishit and Shemot was brought out by **Solomon David Sassoon** (father-in-law of Rabbi Avraham Gabbai of Ohel David in London).

The plan: through the weeks of Bereishit and Shemot (until Pesach), spend about **five minutes each week**, at the start or end of the shiur, on an idea from his commentary. The **Feldheim** edition of HaMaspik includes selected extracts (*likkutim*) at the back, which will serve as the baseline. Flicking through, the Rabbi noticed that many of the ideas tie in closely with HaMaspik — and that Rabbeinu Avraham quotes not only his father but often his **grandfather, Rav Maimon**.

Part One — Review of Chapters 1–9

Why review now: there has been a long break (we learned until the end of July, had one shiur in early September, then the chagim). And **perishut is a very lofty concept** — beyond many of us, the Rabbi included. Learned without the framework of the previous nine chapters it would be out of place. Even with it, it is an aspiration worth learning, and Rabbeinu Avraham's understanding of perishut **seems, at least on the surface, to run starkly against what his father believed and wrote**. We will go into that in detail.

Chapter 1 — Two paths: tzaddik and chasid

Among those who serve Hashem there are two paths. The **tzaddik** fulfils everything required of him. The **chasid** goes beyond. **This book is written for the chasid.**

But there is no point trying to be a chasid if you are not yet a tzaddik. No point being *machmir* in one area while being negligent in another. **Very often, people who are extremely strict in one specific area are unbalanced**: being laser-focused on one thing to the exclusion of everything else usually means they have an issue, often psychological, with that particular topic. If someone is like that in everything, wonderful.

Chapter 2 — The traits are interrelated

Work on one trait and it affects the others. We will see this tonight: **perishut ties in with histapkut** (Chapter 9).

Chapter 3 — Taharah: purity of action, four levels

Level	Why a person serves Hashem
1 (lowest)	**Social pressure.** At least he does it.
2	**To make a good impression on people** — and also because he cares about Hashem
3	**For Hashem, but out of fear or for reward**
4 (highest)	**Because it is simply right and the best life**: *Hashem commanded me; if God commanded it, it must be the best thing to do.*

We should aspire to the fourth level.

Chapter 4 — Rachmanut: compassion

Compassion matters, but it is **not always right**; sometimes a person must use its opposite, **achzariyut**. **When in doubt, veer towards compassion.** The Rambam says the same in **Shemonah Perakim, chapter 4**: although one should be balanced, when in doubt veer towards the better side.

Chapter 5 — Nedivut: generosity

Definition: giving **when there is no need to**.

Towards others	Towards oneself (one's own spending)
miserliness **קמצנות** ↔ generosity **נדיבות**	constant saving **חסכון** ↔ extravagance **בזבוז**

Be generous **to the appropriate people**; it is a mistake to be generous to everyone (as the Gemara says, mercy to the wrong people can be very wrong). Generosity can be with **four things**, all learned from **Avraham Avinu**: (1) **money**, (2) **intellect / wisdom**, (3) **faith / religion**,

(4) **influence / power**. And it **strengthens bitachon** — another example of how the middot interrelate.

Chapter 6 — Arichut apayim: calmness, slowness to anger

Not apathy — apathy is not good. It means **being in control of one's emotions**. It is fine, sometimes correct, to **show displeasure — calmly**. It is no good to harbour anger and not express it, nor to feel anger and express it; work on showing displeasure without anger. **Getting angry is like getting drunk.** Most people get angry at big things and not small ones; to acquire this trait, **don't get angry even at small things**.

How to train:

1. **Remember the consequences.** The Rabbi tells every couple before their wedding: once something is said in anger, **it can't come back** — like toothpaste out of the tube, a boomerang, **כחצים ביד גבור** — an arrow once released.
2. **Anger and arrogance are linked**: often one gets angry because one is arrogant.
3. **The Torah's stories**: those who were not calm (Moshe and the water) and those who were (Yosef forgiving his brothers).
4. **The mitzvot that train patience**: the cities of refuge; rebuking someone (express displeasure rather than harbouring it).

In religious matters one sometimes needs to **show** anger without feeling it, as the prophets did. And **when in doubt whether to show displeasure — refrain.**

The Rabbi's own experience: recently he was **95% certain** it was right to show displeasure. With a 5% doubt, he went ahead — and in retrospect it was wrong. He remembered Rabbeinu Avraham: **unless you are 100% certain, better not to.**

Chapter 7 — Anavah: humility

- **Internal** humility (genuinely felt) and **external** humility (how you walk, dress, speak).
- **Towards Hashem *and* towards people.**

The story: someone says **ונפשי כעפר לכל תהיה** in the Amidah with great kavanah — *my soul shall be like dust* — then finishes and goes off shouting at people. *My soul is dust before Hashem, but not before people?* No: humility is **כלפי הקדוש ברוך הוא and towards other people.**

Very important: humility means recognising your true standing and not exaggerating it. It does **not** mean negating your own talents, abilities and capacity. That is **lowliness**, which is wrong and leads to depression. We live in a world where everyone exaggerates — on the CV, everywhere — to get anywhere. **Anavah means living with who you are.**

How to train:

1. **External humility** — dress, behaviour, speech.
2. **The Torah's stories** — those who lacked humility: Nadav and Avihu, Shaul, Avshalom, Doeg, Yoav and others; and the **twelve mitzvot** that instil anavah (converts, bikkurim, standing for the elderly, monuments and more).

3. **Analyse what people become arrogant about:** purely **physical** things (eating, drinking) — animals have those too; **semi-physical** things (money, power, influence) — they breed hatred, strife and competition, as with kings; **spiritual** things (prophecy, wisdom) — they can be **lost so easily** (as the Moreh teaches, and as this chapter will mention). **Religious arrogance** is also very bad.

Humility doesn't mean degrading yourself: wear **clean, simple** clothes, not dirty ones. A **public figure** sometimes has to act without outward humility — but must stay humble inside.

Chapter 8 — Bitachon (the longest chapter)

Relying on Hashem, Creator of all, to whose will everything is subservient. Not the bitachon of **prophets** (who divest themselves of natural means), and not the view of those who **deny providence** — but the bitachon for the vast majority of us: **Hashem oversees all the natural intermediaries He set in the world.** There are laws of science and physics; we believe in them and learn them, as Aristotle did — and we recognise that Hashem oversees them. So **do your hishtadlut, but don't go overboard**.

Ten categories (five, each in physical and spiritual matters): avoiding seriously harmful situations; avoiding minor harms; attaining what is **essential**; attaining what is **important but not essential**; attaining what is **not important**. He also addressed verses that seem to contradict bitachon.

Four levels of bitachon:

Level	Description
1	Trusts Hashem in his heart — but is **also worried**
2	Trusts and **does things to strengthen the trust, such as prayer** — *we should all aim for at least this*
3	**Complete trust and confidence**: he knows it will happen
4 (highest)	**Doesn't even "place" his trust**, because whatever happens is good from Hashem

Chapter 9 — Histapkut: contentment

Contentment prevents jealousy and the pursuit of unimportant things. Train for it by **aspiring only to what is necessary**. The Torah's stories teach its importance.

Part Two — Rabbeinu Avraham on Bereishit

1. Why "טוב מאד"?

וירא אלהים את כל אשר עשה, והנה טוב מאד; ויהי ערב ויהי בקר יום הששי. (Bereishit 1:31)

The question: **"אחר שאמר השם יתעלה בפרטי הבריאה "כי טוב", "כי טוב** — each day already said *ki tov*. Why repeat **טוב** at the end, and add **מאד**?

His answer: מפני מציאות האדם המשיג ענייני העולם — it is human nature to try to understand the world around us.

- **Some things we can see the benefit of immediately:** the sun, the moon, the heavens and the earth; most species of animals and plants.
- **Some are beyond us: וקצתם נשגב מן האדם אופן הכוונה במציאותם והתועלת בהם.** *(The Rabbi: why do we need millions upon millions of stars and galaxies? To show Hashem's glory, perhaps — but it is hard to say.)*
- **Some even seem better uncreated: ולא עוד, אלא אפשר שיעלה על הדעת במקצתם שמוטב שלא נבראו — כמציאות העקרב והנחש... והארי והדב... והתמסח** — the scorpion, the snake, the lion, the bear, the **crocodile**.

> **ואין ראוי לאדם שיסמוך בטוב בריאתו יתעלה על הבנתו ועל מה שיגיע אליו שכלו, אלא ידע כי לשכלו ולדעתו גבול אשר יגיע אליו.**

We cannot rely on our own intellect to decide what was worth creating. **Our understanding has a limit.** But because God is perfect, **everything He creates is "very good" — whether we understand it or not.** That is what the verse says.

אילו ידעתיו הייתיו — *If I knew Him, I would be Him."* Often attributed to Rav Saadia; the Rabbi thinks it is actually **Rav Yosef Albo, in the Ikkarim**.

David HaMelech says the same:

מה רבו מעשיך ה', כלם בחכמה עשית (Tehillim 104 — Rosh Chodesh) Do I always understand them? No. But I know they are all **with wisdom**.

פליאה דעת ממני, נשגבה לא אוכל לה (Tehillim 139) some knowledge is too lofty for me.

והראוי לאדם להסתכל במה שנסתפקו הקדמונים בתועלתו ושנעלם מהם — look at things whose benefit earlier generations doubted and which we now understand.

The Rabbi's example: the appendix — as far as he knows, we still don't know what it is for; that's why it's called an *appendix*. But many things in the body and in nature were once a mystery and are now understood. Just as then, so now: **every part of nature has a purpose. It is טוב מאד.** *Simple ideas — but beautiful.*

2. Why "ויפח" — He *breathed*?

ויפח באפיו נשמת חיים, ויהי האדם לנפש חיה. (Bereishit 2:7)

(This verse opens Chapter 10 tonight.) As we learn in the Moreh: everything is **chomer** (matter) and **tzurah** (form). Hashem made Adam **עפר מן האדמה** — that is the chomer — and gave him a **tzurah**: intellect, consciousness, the mind, what we call the **neshamah**. **Why describe the giving of the form as *blowing*?**

> **כדי לקרב אל הבנתנו יושר השכל ודקות אותה צורה שכלית, שהרוחות וכדומה נראה יותר זך מן הגשמים האחרים שאנו מכירים.**

To convey **how subtle the form is**. Of all our senses, the most subtle is **breath and smell**. Hence the Chachamim's play on **כל הנשמה תהלל יה** — read it as **כל הנשימה**: *for every single breath* we should praise Hashem. The soul and the breath go together. By contrast, the

Rambam famously writes that **touch is the most shameful of the senses**. **Smell is the sense most associated with the neshamah** — so the Torah uses **ויפח** for implanting the tzurah.

Part Three — Chapter 10: Perishut (Introduction)

What perishut is — and the problem

לפרוש means to abstain. The chapter's purpose: **try to abstain from what is unnecessary.** This is clearly **chasidut**. By the Torah itself — depending on how one understands **קדושים תהיו** — a person could arguably eat all the meat he wants, marry many wives and so on, all within the Torah's permission, and still be a **tzaddik** who has kept the whole Torah. **Rabbeinu Avraham is urging us to go beyond that: to be a chasid, and to abstain.**

The problem: those who learned the **Shemonah Perakim** with the Rabbi (about two and a half to three years ago) know that **the Rambam wrote against this**. We cannot examine that until we have seen what Rabbeinu Avraham says. **Keep it in mind; we will come back to it.**

You may feel you're not there yet. There is still value in learning this, as we will see. And the opening of the chapter is really an **introduction** — almost a continuation of Chapter 9 — on understanding, and being content with, the physical world.

The material world is a barrier

העולם החומרי הוא מחיצה גדולה החוצצת בין הבריאה לבין בוראו.

The physical world is **a great partition between creation and its Creator**.

כי האדם מורכב מחומר יסודי, כמו שאמרה התורה: וייצר ה' אלהים את האדם עפר מן האדמה; והיתה אצילות הנשמה מעולם העליון — והוא שהתכוון אליו הכתוב באמרו: בצלם אלהים, בדמותו.

Man is made of **elemental matter** — dust from the ground — and of a soul **from the upper world**: the **צלם אלהים**, which is the **intellect**, exactly as his father explains in **Moreh I:1**.

וכן אמר הכתוב על הקשר והצירוף של שניהם: ויפח באפיו נשמת חיים. — the joining of the two: He breathed the tzurah into the chomer.

ויהי האדם לנפש חיה — man became a **living being** only once the neshamah was breathed in. **We are truly called alive only when we have the tzurah.**

*(Compare **Rav Saadia, Emunot VeDeot, Essay 6**, on the soul: you cannot have a body without a soul, nor a soul without a body.)*

והחומר בעצמו אין לו שום פעולה או תועלת, אלא כל כוחות האדם פועלים באמצעות הצורה.

לפיכך אין המת רואה ואינו שומע ואינו טועם, אף על פי שכל איבריו קיימים because — **הכוחות הרוחניים שקשורים באיברים נפסקו מן הגוף.**

A person who has just died has every limb intact — and can do nothing, because the **tzurah** has gone.

וכן הקשר בין האדם לבין קונו קיים באמצעות הצורה, שבעזרתה יבין וישיג מה שישיג מגדולת בוראו, ויהיה קרוב אליו.

Our relationship with Hashem exists through the tzurah, by which we understand what we can of His greatness.

ובעלות הצורה הזאת אל מקורה — שם היא תהנה ותתענג עונג רב. ובירידתה אל מצולות השכבה התחתונה, שהיא החומר — תחשך תקוותנו מכך, וייבצר מאיתנו האושר הגדול שהשם ייעד לנו, שנאמר: באורך נראה אור.

The more a person develops the tzurah, the more he will relate to Hashem when it returns to its source. **The more he is sucked into physicality, the more the tzurah is covered** and the harder the relationship becomes. *(We see this at length in the Rambam, and in the **Ramchal's Derech Hashem and Da'at Tevunot**.)*

How the pursuit of wealth swallows a life

ולכן מי שלהוט אחר הבלי העולם הזה ותאב לקנייניו — כגון הון, רכוש וכבוד — ומשתוקק לתענוגיו — כגון אכילה, שתייה, משגל וכיוצא בהם — הרי זה מוציא זמנו לריק... וגורם לנשמתו להתפשט מטה עמהם.

The target that never arrives

"Once I've made X, I'll relax." People do this all the time. But **על פי רוב אין לה שיעור** — usually there is no real limit, **כמו שאמר החכם: אוהב כסף לא ישבע כסף**.

Even with a fixed target: suppose you calculate it all — enough for you, your wife and children until you're 120, homes for your grandchildren and great-grandchildren, inflation... you'd be talking **£100 million plus**. Fine — *once I reach that, I'll relax.*

...שיסע במדבר או בים במשך שנים... ונמצא מבזבז את מרבית חייו כדי לנסות להשיג אותה.

He travels the deserts and seas for years. **Nothing has changed:** the Rabbi has noticed that **the wealthier people are, the more they are away on business** — half the time they're not even here. Buying and selling, the stocks... **most of a life spent trying to reach it.**

ימיו — עייפות ויגיעה, as David says: **יצא אדם לפעלו ולעבדתו עדי ערב**.

ולילותיו — שינה עמוקה כדומם, מרוב עייפות, as it says: **מתוקה שנת העבד**.

And in his few free hours?

הרי טרוד במחשבות שמא טעה בדברים שהתעסק בהם בעבר, או בדברים שיתעסק בהם בעתיד.

The Rabbi knows an extremely wealthy elderly man who wakes **two or three times a night** — goes to the toilet, **checks the stocks**, goes back to sleep if he can.

Even his dreams:

אין מראין לו לאדם אלא מהרהורי לבו, as Daniel said to Nevuchadnezzar: **אנת מלכא רעיונך על משכבך סלקו.**

כמו שאמר שלמה: כי כל ימיו מכאבים וכעס ענינו, גם בלילה לא שכב לבו.

וכך ישאר על פי רוב עד יום מותו, ולא ישיג תאוותו. — most people, and this is 100% true, never reach the target.

And if he does reach it — two options

Option 1 — hoard it.

או שישמור את הונו ויצפינהו במשמרות הראויות, כדרך הקמצנים, of whom Shlomo said: **יש רעה אשר ראיתי... איש אשר יתן לו האלהים עשר... ולא ישליטנו האלהים לאכל ממנו, כי איש נכרי יאכלנו — זה הבל וחלי רע הוא.**

"I worked so hard for it — how can I spend it?" **How often do we see it:** people make millions upon millions, hoard it or give very little, then die — and half goes on **lawsuits**, the other half to **charities that abuse the money**. He never enjoyed it.

וחושב תמיד כיצד יסתיר את הונו וישמרהו מבעלי גנבות.

And he is constantly worried about losing it: if you are worth billions, **from one night to the next you can double, or lose half**. Imagine losing half your wealth overnight! And when he is forced to spend something, **he grieves without end** — and then must refill it.

Option 2 — spend it on pleasures.

שיוציאנו בתאוותיו ותענוגיו...

Yachts, beautiful homes scattered around the world, feasts, banquets. But:

דרוש זמן רב ומחשבה רבה כדי לקבוע את הדברים הללו.

"I have to sort out my property here, and my property there..." — the bills for each property, the **insurance on each car**. The Rabbi has heard this over and over, secretaries notwithstanding.

ולמשל, אם יתעורר לבנות לו בית גדול ונאה — יחפוץ שיהא תואר הבית ומלאכתו מעשיהם של מומחים... — ...the finest kitchen, the finest wallpaper, the research

ואם עומד הוא לערוך משתה מעדנים... יחפוץ להקדיש יום תמים, אם לא למעלה מזה, להכנת המשתה.

A whole day to prepare a banquet, he says. **Nowadays, months.** The Rabbi has seen couples **delay their wedding by six months or a year** — *"because we need to prepare the wedding"* — for one day that lasts a few hours, after which everyone has a stomach ache.

ועל כל זאת, אם תדלדלו בבזבוז הוצאות עד שההון שהשיגו כלה — יחלו למלאות החסר... וכך יאבדו חייהם לריק ביגון ואנחה.

Spend it all, then spend the rest of life refilling it.

The Rabbi: these are simple points — **but the beauty of the Ba'al HaMechaber is that the simplicity itself reminds us of their truth.**

"The unlearned grow more foolish with age"

וכל כמה שיאריכו הימים — תחלש התקשרות הנפש למקורה.

The longer such a person lives, the weaker the soul's bond to its source. And with this Rabbeinu Avraham gives **a new explanation** of the Chachamim:

> **זקני עמי הארץ, כל זמן שמזקינין — טפשות מתוספת בהם**, as it says: **מסיר שפה לנאמנים, וטעם זקנים יקח** (Iyov 12:20).

ולכן רואה אתה זקניהם, כשהם תשושים וקרובה מיתתם... מרבים הבלים ושיחה בטלה: "כעת עשינו, וכעת חרשנו, וכעת ראינו, וכעת הפסדנו, וכעת הרווחנו" — והוא מבוקי סריקי, as it says: **הקץ לדברי רוח?** (Iyov 16:3)

People who did not live fulfilling lives talk more and more nonsense as they age.
Why? Because the longer the neshamah lives in the darkness of a purely physical identity, the

more detached it becomes from its source.

The Rabbi's application: if I spend my 120 years working on **both** — looking after my body, my health, my exercise, *and* my spiritual identity — wonderful. But if I spend my whole life on my **guf** alone, **the longer my neshamah is in my body, the more detached it becomes from its makor — and the "more foolish" I become.** *"Very interesting. I never thought of it like that."*

After death: the soul and כף הקלע

עד שיבוא עליהם המוות, וינתק הקשר בין גוף לנפש, ותפול הנפש בענויים קשים.

ויפסקו ממנה תענוגות העולם הזה שהשתוקקה להם, ויהא לה מכאוב כמכאובו של הסומא בהעדר עונג הראיה שאבד לו.

Notice this line carefully: the pain of **a blind man who once could see** — he knows the pleasures of colour and sight, and no longer has them. Your soul will feel the same, because **its whole identity was its physical identity**, and that is gone. (**אך בשרו עליו יכאב ונפשו עליו תאבל** — Iyov 14:22.) **That is (a).**

יתר על כן, לא תהא לה גישה לדברים שלא נתעסקה בהם בחייה בעולם הזה, מן השלמויות שהם יסוד והקדמה לשלמות הנצחית.

(b): it will have **no access to the spiritual perfections**, because it never worked on that part of itself — and it will be in constant pain.

ותיחשב עם אלה שנגזר עליהם יסורי הנפש ומבוכתה, כמו שנאמר: ואת נפש איביך יקלענה בתוך כף הקלע.

Kaf hakela — Kabbalah?

כף הקלע is a phrase much used in **Kabbalah** (the Rabbi wasn't sure whether in the Zohar or the Arizal): the soul of a rasha is **slung from one end of the universe to the other**, perpetually. Some would say: *here's a proof that the Rambam and Rabbeinu Avraham secretly knew Kabbalah, though they never mention a word of it!* So let's look at the verse, the Gemara and the Rishonim.

The verse

Avigayil is calming **David** after **Naval** disgraced him and David wants revenge — *as so often, it is the women who calm us down*:

ויקם אדם לרדפך ולבקש את נפשך, והיתה נפש אדני צרורה בצרור החיים את ה' אלהיך, ואת נפש איביך יקלענה בתוך כף הקלע. (Shmuel I 25:29)

Don't take revenge — your soul is bound up with Hashem, and He will deal with your enemy. **Rashi: כף הקלע** is simply **the wide piece of leather in the middle of a sling, in which the stone is placed.**

The Gemara (Shabbat 152b)

תניא, רבי אליעזר אומר: נשמתן של צדיקים גנוזות תחת כסא הכבוד, שנאמר: והיתה נפש אדני צרורה בצרור החיים — *(on so many gravestones hence)* ***תהי נשמתו צרורה בצרור החיים***.

ושל רשעים זוממות והולכות, ומלאך אחד עומד בסוף העולם ומלאך אחד עומד בסוף העולם, ומקלעין נשמתן זה לזה, שנאמר: ואת נפש איביך יקלענה בתוך כף הקלע.

Avigayil and David were not speaking of the World to Come, but the Gemara is *doresh* it — and **from this developed the Kabbalistic concept of כף הקלע**: the wicked in perpetual torment, thrown from end to end.

Ralbag

"והיתה נפש אדני צרורה בצרור החיים" — עולם הבא... "ואת נפש איביך יקלענה בתוך כף הקלע" — רוצה לומר: שלא יהיה לה השארות וקיום.

No survival and no existence. As we have learned in the Rambam many times (Hilchot Teshuvah and elsewhere), **karet** — the greatest punishment — is that **the soul ceases to exist**. You sling a stone, and it is gone. This is how the Rabbi would understand the verse in the Rambam's framework.

The Rabbi's open question

Whom is Rabbeinu Avraham describing?

Reading	Implication
(a) Someone who has received karet	Then we have a **clear proof** that Rabbeinu Avraham — and most likely the Rambam, since such a major point would come from his father — held that **even after karet, some element of identity remains intact, enough to feel that it has been cut off**: the pain of no access to the spiritual, and of losing the physical pleasures it loved. The Rabbi thinks (from inferences, not a full proof) that the **Ramchal** held this; **Rabbi Daniel Rowlands** believes the Ramchal definitely did.
(b) Someone in Olam Haba, at a very low level	He has some connection, but a weak one, because he keeps thinking of the physical and isn't tuned for the spiritual. *Like getting into a top university — and then sitting there thinking: was it worth it? I'm out of place here.*

The Rabbi isn't sure. **He considers this a key passage** for understanding what the Rambam and Rabbeinu Avraham held happens after karet — and there is very little commentary on Rabbeinu Avraham. **Ralbag** fits the view that you simply cease to exist; **Rabbeinu Avraham seems to say there is perpetual pain.**

Elisha and Gechazi: "Is there a time to take?"

ובכן, מי ששקוע בהבלי העולם הזה — הרי הוא מוסת ומפותה, ומעלים ומפסיד מעיקרו של עניינו.

Engross your life in the mundane, and that becomes your identity. **Therefore Elisha said to Gechazi:**

The story: Elisha healed **Naaman** of tzara'at; Naaman wanted to pay; Elisha refused. Gechazi saw, ran after Naaman, and took the money. Elisha found out:

העת לקחת את הכסף, ולקחת בגדים וזיתים וכרמים וצאן ובקר ועבדים ושפחות? (Melachim II 5:26)

hiding it from me isn't the main problem; you — **כדי לרכוש זיתים וכרמים ועבדים ושפחות...** wanted the money **to buy more physical things**.

ותמוה הדבר שתהיה תלמיד נביא ותעסוק בכך.

הסבור אתה שזמננו הקצר, שהוא כמידת חיינו בעולם הזה, נועד כדי לרכוש קניינים גשמיים כאלה ולהתענג בהם כהמון העם?

וכי זה מנהגם של נביאים וחסידים, מנעוריהם עד שנזדקנו, להשיג תענוגות אלה ולבלות בהן שנותיהם?

The simple meaning of **העת לקחת**, the Rabbi thinks, is *"Is this the appropriate time to take?"* — it's not the moment to take from Naaman. **Rabbeinu Avraham reads it differently: "Is there *any* time to take?"** For a prophet or a prophet's student, **there is no time in this world for this.** Our time is short.

Summary

The review: Chapter 1 — tzaddik before chasid; 2 — the traits interconnect; 3 — four levels of purity of action, aiming for *"it is simply right"*; 4 — compassion, and when in doubt veer to it; 5 — generosity, to the right people, with money, wisdom, faith and influence; 6 — calmness: show displeasure without anger, and when in doubt refrain; 7 — humility as accurate self-knowledge, towards Hashem and people; 8 — bitachon in Hashem's oversight of nature, in ten categories and four levels; 9 — contentment.

Rabbeinu Avraham on Bereishit: טוב מאד — everything Hashem made is very good even where we can't see why; our understanding has limits. **ויפח** — breath, the subtlest sense, conveys the subtlety of the soul.

Chapter 10 (introduction): perishut — abstaining from the unnecessary — is chasidut beyond the Torah's requirement, and seems to conflict with the Rambam (to be examined). Man is chomer and tzurah; the body is alive and functions only through the tzurah, and our bond with Hashem runs through it. **The material world is a barrier**: wealth has no natural endpoint; it consumes days, nights, spare hours and dreams; if attained it is either hoarded in anxiety or spent in endless management and then refilled. **A life lived only in the body weakens the soul's bond with its source** — Rabbeinu Avraham's new reading of *the unlearned grow more foolish with age*. After death such a soul suffers the loss of the pleasures it lived for and has no access to the spiritual — **כף הקלע**, which the Gemara reads as being slung from end to end and Ralbag as ceasing to exist, leaving open whether Rabbeinu Avraham means conscious pain after karet or a low place in Olam Haba. And Elisha's **העת לקחת?** means: **there is no time in a short life for this.**

Coming Up

- **Next week, 6:00–7:00pm:** the **definition of perishut and its benefits** — and how all this ties into perishut. We will return to the apparent conflict with **the Rambam's Shemonah Perakim**.
- A short idea from **Rabbeinu Avraham on the parashah** each week through Bereishit and Shemot.
- Chapter 10 should take about **four shiurim**, then Chapters 11–13 — finishing **by Pesach**.

B'Ezrat Hashem

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